

3. Consumer Debt exceeds the National Debt.
4. A CEO of Provident said, “The goal is to squeeze out revenue and get the customers to sit still for the squeeze.”
5. In 2004, thirty states sued banks regarding predatory practices.
6. The Federal Trade Commission used to have two lawyers to handle the collection agency suits. Presently, more than 100 attorneys are processing these suits.
7. 83% of all divorces are attributed to money problems.
8. The number one cause of bankruptcy is health care bills.
9. Between 1994 and 2004, over 10 million Americans filed for bankruptcy.
10. Being in debt now does not mean that you will be in debt forever.

If you answered “true” to all of the above, you are correct. If you answered “sad, but true” to all but the last statement, you are also correct.

Sad, Sad World

Those statistics above are astonishing. We are a credit card society. The convenience is wonderful. The fees are not. The industry has made it too easy to get too many cards and too much credit. Many people mistakenly believe the credit card company or the bank would not give them a card unless they could afford it. “I must be doing okay. The bank just gave me another credit card.”

You *are* doing okay, in their eyes. The old joke about corrupt voting practices in Chicago was “vote early, vote often.” The credit card industry may have a similar motto – pay little, pay late, pay forever.

The outlandish fees that they are raking in are unbelievable. The biggest increase in revenue is fees! And the big wig of the big bank wrote in an email how he wants us all to sit still for “the squeeze.” Outrageous. But then again, this is the company who paid \$400 million to settle allegations of fraud and other egregious acts against its own customers. How much more preposterous can it get?